PORTLAND | Public Schools

RIGHTSIZE. RIGHT SUPPORTS. RIGHT FOR STUDENTS.

Methodology

How Portland Public Schools developed the proposed changes: the data behind the model, the criteria the district weighed, and how those criteria were applied region by region.

Overview

The proposed changes were developed by district leaders and district planning staff, guided by a set of criteria that reflect what the district is trying to achieve: schools large enough to offer stable, adequately resourced programming, buildings used well, and school communities kept together through change as much as possible.

These criteria often pull in different directions. Keeping a school community together may require a larger boundary change. Consolidating a small immersion program may lengthen some students' trips. For that reason, the criteria were weighed against one another rather than applied as a fixed ranking, and the balance struck differs from one part of the city to another, because conditions differ.

Two scenarios were developed, which differ mainly in how many schools they close. A scenario that closes fewer schools affects fewer families and changes fewer boundaries, but leaves more schools below the enrollment at which a school can offer stable, fully resourced programming. A scenario that closes more schools does the reverse.

Data Sets and Structure

The model uses the following data sets structured into four primary inputs and a unified output.

DATA SOURCE	ORIGIN / FORMAT	DESCRIPTION & OPERATIONAL PURPOSE
1. Base Projections	Portland State University Population Research Center	10-year official enrollment projections broken down by school, group (program type/residency), grade (PK–12), and year Base line year: 2025-26 (actual enrollment) Projections through 2031-32
2. Scenario Configuration	Portland Public School Central Office Administration	User-defined policy moves (e.g., "Merge School A into School B" or "Transition School C to K-5") specifying percentage moves, grade ranges, implementation year, and phased vs. immediate timing
3. Historical Proportions	PPS 3-Year Historical Averages	Granular matrix mapping how students enrolled in specific schools and programs naturally distribute back across home neighborhood boundaries, supporting 1-to-many closures
4. Facility Capacity Data	PPS Facility Operations	Standardized building capacity numbers, classroom counts, square footage, and baseline utilization rates from the District Utilization model.
5. Unified Output	Result Table	Centralized storage location feeding Power BI dashboards for real-time visualization and comparative scenario analysis. All outputs originate from the same source ensuring accuracy of reporting.

Methodology

Portland Public Schools (PPS) is addressing prolonged declining enrollment which has led to varied educational experiences for students through this rightsizing process. The goal is to create schools that are able to weather enrollment fluctuations and consistently provide more equitable learning environments for students. These decisions include:

- **Closing schools**
- **Transitioning K8 schools to K5 schools and assigning middle grades students to existing middle schools**
- **Consolidating Dual Language Immersion (DLI) programs**
- **Redrawing neighborhood boundaries**
- **Closing focus programs**
- **Moving programs to co-locate with other programs**

To understand the scale of change required, we modeled two scenarios, one in which half of our schools reach sustainable enrollment levels, and one in which seventy percent do by 2031-32

PORTLAND | Public Schools

Criteria Framework

To identify which schools would be affected, PPS weighed multiple factors. While the criteria considered were held across regions, different priorities emerged depending on location. They are listed below.

CRITERIA	GOAL
Consolidate Dual Language Immersion Programs *so that each language pathway is sustainable*	No more than one same-language DLI program per region
Sustainable Enrollment Threshold *so that every school can offer stable and comparable learning experiences*	**By the 2031-32 school year** Elementary Schools: **360 students** Middle schools and K8 schools: **500 students** High schools: **1,100 students**
Minimize the Number of Receiving Schools from a Closure *to keep school communities together*	If a school site is closed, try to keep the students moving together to one new site where possible and do not move them to more than two new sites.
Minimize Boundary Changes *to smallest number of students possible*	Support maintaining cohorts of students moving through the system together and minimizing local neighborhood disruptions
Account for Facility Improvements *so that students are learning in the highest quality physical environment*	Use school buildings that have received recent improvements or have improvements planned as much as possible

PORTLAND | Public Schools

Criteria Framework

CRITERIA	GOAL
Compact Boundaries *so that students can access schools close to where they live*	To promote safer routes to schools and minimize distance between students and their schools, identify percent of students living within 1.0 miles of an elementary and 1.5 miles of a middle school.
Optimize Use of Existing Facilities *so buildings can accommodate future growth and academic programming*	Use buildings efficiently that support academic programming and long-term operational viability **Between 70% and 100%**
Review School Demographics *to describe who benefits and is burdened by the changes*	Are the students experiencing the changes reflective of our district demographics overall
Minimize Split Feeders *so that cohorts of students can move through the*	Increase the number of groups of students who move together from one grade level to the next, for example all students at one middle school moving to the same high school

Applying Criteria

The data and modeling team included all schools and programs across the district. As changes were modeled they were considered by region. Each region was formed based on two adjacent high school attendance areas. The four regions include Ida B. Wells and Lincoln on the west side, Jefferson and Roosevelt in the north, Grant and MacDaniel in the northeast, and Cleveland and Franklin in the southeast. The primary drivers of scenario development were to stabilize elementaries and middle schools, establish clear dual language immersion pathways, and reduce the number of split feeder patterns. Each of those schools was then compared with other schools in the same region using the criteria above. The result is a set of recommendations shaped not only by how a school's current enrollment compares to its sustainable threshold, but by the full set of priorities the district committed to weighing.

> **HELD CONSTANT IN THE MODEL**
>
> **Factors that remained the same throughout the modeling:** number of kindergarten seats available for dual language immersion, languages offered in dual language immersion programs, seats available at ACCESS, Benson, da Vinci, and Winterhaven, and schools or programs with specific entrance requirements are not included such as DART.

Scenario Enrollment Assumptions

In each scenario the implementation begins with the 2027-2028 school year and ends with all changes being completed by the beginning of the 2028-2029 school year. The scenarios assume the PSU projection of students will be enrolled in PPS during all years.